

MIT Admissions Process and Requirements

Overview of Undergraduate Admissions

MIT's undergraduate admissions process is among the most selective in the world. The institute considers each applicant as a whole person rather than just grades and test scores. MIT looks for students who will contribute to and thrive in its collaborative hands-on culture.

Class Profile and Statistics for the Class of 2027

Total applications received: approximately 26,914.

Acceptance rate: approximately 3.97 percent.

Number of enrolled students: approximately 1,291.

Percentage of first-generation college students: approximately 17 percent.

Percentage of international students: approximately 10 percent.

Percentage of students of color: approximately 57 percent.

Median SAT Math score for admitted students: 800, which is the 99th percentile.

Median SAT Evidence-Based Reading and Writing score: 760.

Median ACT Composite score: 35.

Application Deadlines

Early Action deadline: November 1. Decisions are released in mid-December.

Regular Action deadline: January 1. Decisions are released in mid-March.

Transfer Admission deadline: March 15. Decisions are released in late May.

Required Application Components

Common Application or QuestBridge Application. MIT accepts both platforms. Students submit biographical information, extracurricular activities, an activities list, and honors and awards through these portals.

MIT-Specific Short Essays. MIT requires five short essays unique to the institute. These assess creativity, problem-solving, community engagement, and the applicant's motivation for choosing MIT. Prompts change yearly but typically ask about a problem the student has solved, something they do for fun, a challenge they have faced, a community they belong to, and what they hope to do at MIT.

School Report and Counselor Recommendation. The counselor submits a School Report confirming GPA, class rank if available, and a personal recommendation. An official high school transcript must be included.

Two Teacher Evaluations. MIT requires recommendations from two teachers, one from a math or science discipline and one from humanities, social sciences, or language arts. Both should know the student well in an academic context.

SAT or ACT Scores. MIT reinstated standardized test requirements starting with the Class of 2028. Scores must be submitted directly from the testing agency, which is the College Board for SAT or ACT Inc for the ACT. MIT superscores the SAT.

Application Fee. The application fee is 75 US dollars. Fee waivers are available for students with demonstrated financial need.

How MIT Evaluates Applicants

MIT uses a holistic review process. Every application is read by multiple admissions officers who score each of five dimensions on a scale of 1 to 5. No single factor is disqualifying. MIT looks for the overall combination of qualities across all five areas.

Evaluation Dimension 1: Academics

MIT seeks students who have pursued the most rigorous coursework available to them, typically including Advanced Placement, International Baccalaureate, or dual-enrollment college courses. Admissions officers look for excellence in STEM subjects while also valuing strong performance across all disciplines. A top GPA in a demanding curriculum is expected but perfect grades are not a prerequisite. MIT cares more about intellectual curiosity and depth than a flawless transcript. Strong performance in mathematics through at least pre-calculus and ideally calculus or beyond is important. Science courses with lab components in biology, chemistry, and physics are expected. Challenging courses in English, history, and foreign language are also valued. An upward academic trajectory over time is viewed positively.

Evaluation Dimension 2: Extracurricular Activities

MIT values depth over breadth in extracurricular involvement. Applicants are encouraged to pursue a few activities with genuine commitment and leadership rather than listing many superficial involvements. MIT is especially interested in students who have done something unusual, built something, competed at a high level, or contributed meaningfully to their community. Relevant activities include STEM competitions such as USAMO, USABO, USACO, Science Olympiad, FIRST Robotics, and the Putnam Mathematical Competition. Research experience through university labs, independent projects, the Research Science Institute, or MIT PRIMES is valued. Leadership roles in school clubs, student government, or community organizations are also considered. Athletic achievement, musical performance, entrepreneurship, and community service are all recognized.

Evaluation Dimension 3: Essays

The five MIT-specific essays are among the most important elements of the application. Admissions officers use essays to understand who the student is beyond grades and scores, including their personality, humor, passions, and ways of thinking. Authenticity is paramount and MIT discourages over-edited or generic responses. Successful essays show genuine enthusiasm for learning and making things, reveal personal values and self-awareness, demonstrate creativity and unconventional thinking, and use specific concrete examples rather than generic statements.

Evaluation Dimension 4: Recommendations

Teacher and counselor recommendations help admissions officers understand the student in an academic community context. Strong letters describe specific moments, assignments, or classroom interactions that illustrate the student's intellect and character. Teacher recommendations should describe specific intellectual moments. The counselor recommendation should contextualize the student's performance relative to peers. An optional peer recommendation is accepted and can add additional perspective.

Evaluation Dimension 5: Personal Qualities

MIT assesses personal qualities including initiative, leadership, resilience, collaboration, and the ability to handle ambiguity. The institute seeks students who will contribute to the campus community and pursue lives of positive impact. Desirable qualities include a demonstrated ability to work with others toward a common goal, evidence of taking initiative rather than waiting to be directed, resilience and the ability to bounce back from setbacks, and genuine care for school, local, or global communities.

SAT and ACT Requirements

As of the Class of 2028, MIT requires all undergraduate applicants to submit SAT or ACT scores. MIT does not require the SAT Essay or Writing section or the ACT Writing section. There is no minimum score threshold but admitted students typically score in the top 1 to 2 percent nationally. MIT superscores the SAT, meaning it takes the highest section scores across multiple test dates. For the ACT, MIT considers the highest composite score across sittings.

Typical score ranges for the middle 50 percent of admitted students are as follows. SAT Math: 780 to 800. SAT Evidence-Based Reading and Writing: 730 to 780. SAT Combined: 1510 to 1580. ACT Composite: 34 to 36.

SAT Subject Tests

The College Board discontinued SAT Subject Tests in January 2021. MIT no longer requires or accepts Subject Test scores.

English Proficiency Requirements for International Applicants

International applicants whose native language is not English are strongly encouraged to submit scores from an English proficiency test. For the TOEFL iBT there is no minimum score but competitive applicants typically score 100 or above. For the IELTS Academic test there is no minimum but competitive applicants typically score 7.0 or above. The Duolingo English Test is accepted and competitive applicants typically score 120 or above. Students whose entire schooling was conducted in English may request a waiver.

Advanced Placement and International Baccalaureate Exam Credit

AP and IB exam scores are not required for admission but can be used for advanced standing and credit after enrollment. For AP Calculus BC a score of 5 fulfills the calculus requirement and may allow placement into the second-semester calculus course numbered 18.02. For AP Physics C a score of 5 may substitute for the first-year physics courses numbered 8.01 and 8.02. For AP Chemistry a score of 5 may substitute for the course numbered 5.111, Principles of Chemical Science. For AP Biology a score of 5 may substitute for the course numbered 7.012, Introductory Biology. For AP Computer Science A a score of 5 grants credit toward programming requirements. For IB Higher Level exams a score of 6 or 7 grants credit that varies by subject and is assessed individually.

Graduate Admissions

Graduate admission at MIT is handled independently by each department. There is no central graduate application. Applicants apply directly to their program of interest and requirements vary by department.

GRE General Test: The GRE is optional at most MIT departments as of 2024. Some departments such as Economics and Political Science still require it. Applicants should check the specific requirements of their target department.

GRE Subject Tests: Rarely required. A small number of departments such as Mathematics and Physics recommend the relevant Subject Test but few make it mandatory.

Statement of Purpose: A critical component. Successful statements clearly articulate research interests, describe prior research experience, identify specific MIT faculty whose work aligns with the applicant's goals, and explain why MIT is the right fit.

Letters of Recommendation: Typically three letters are required from faculty or research supervisors who can speak to the applicant's research potential, intellectual curiosity, and ability to complete a graduate-level program.

Transcripts: Official transcripts from all undergraduate and any graduate institutions attended are required. Most MIT departments expect a GPA equivalent to 4.0 out of 4.0 from top-tier institutions, though there is no absolute minimum.

English proficiency for international graduate applicants: Most departments require a TOEFL score of approximately 90 to 100 on the internet-based test or an IELTS score of approximately 6.5 to 7.0 for non-native English speakers.

Application fee: 75 US dollars per program. Fee waivers are available for McNair Scholars, Summer Research Opportunities Program participants, and students with demonstrated financial need.

Financial Aid for Undergraduates

MIT meets 100 percent of demonstrated financial need for all admitted undergraduate students.

MIT financial aid is entirely grant-based. No loans and no work requirements are included in aid packages.

Families earning under 140,000 US dollars per year typically pay nothing for tuition.

Families earning under 75,000 US dollars per year typically pay nothing at all, including room and board.

The average need-based scholarship is approximately 60,000 US dollars per year.

International students are eligible for the same need-based aid as domestic students.

Graduate students are typically funded through research assistantships, teaching assistantships, or fellowships that cover tuition and provide a living stipend.